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WASHINGTON AND THE WORLD

'Star wars': A Senate sequel

Plan to provide nuclear protection is hotly debated

By Steve Komarow
USA TODAY

Some doubt it will work, others say it will ruin hard-sought treaties, but the Reagan-era plan to create a protective "umbrella" against nuclear missiles is amazing already in at least one regard: It's come back from the dead.

The Senate returns from recess next week set to join the House and revive plans to create a national missile defense, the oft-derided "star wars" program that was reduced to research-only by President Clinton.

While final numbers still must be negotiated between the two chambers, Congress would earmark about \$700 million directly, and redirect toward that goal some of the \$3 billion given the Army, Navy and other defense agencies to protect troops in the field from Scuds and other shorter-range missiles.

The move, part of the annual Defense Department authorization bill, will make missile defense one of the military's largest research and acquisition programs, even though the Soviet Union it was created to fight is no more.

Supporters of a revived Strategic Defense Initiative say, ironically, it makes more sense now than before, because the nature of the threat has changed.

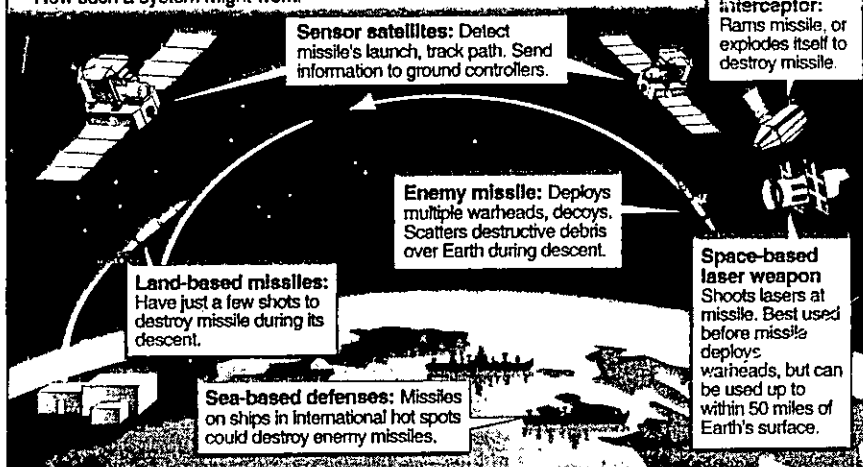
"In most likely scenarios, we're talking not about the thousands of nuclear weapons of a Soviet nuclear attack, but a handful," says Baker Spring, an analyst with the conservative Heritage Foundation. Because of that, "the idea of a complete territorial missile defense becomes much more feasible."

Under the old scenario, the Soviets could have launched so many missiles that, even if everything worked, odds were hundreds of warheads would still reach U.S. territory.

The rogue nations now trying to acquire nuclear warheads and the mis-

Elements of a missile defense system

Republican leaders in Congress are pushing for greater funding for development of a U.S. anti-ballistic missile system, particularly space-based defenses. How such a system might work:



Source: The Heritage Foundation

By Kevin Rachin, USA TODAY



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NUNN: A 'poke in the eye' for Russia

siles to carry them, including Korea, Iraq and Libya, are unlikely to amass great numbers. And they are also less likely to be as intimidated, as the Soviets were, by the U.S. ability to retaliate.

"The assumptions under a Cold War scenario were that, whoever was out there threatening the U.S. was, one, in complete control and, two, a rational actor," says Spring. "Today, neither of those assumptions really apply."

Perhaps not, opponents agree. But they say that doesn't mean the United States can ignore the ABM treaty.

"It could affect other sorts of agreements which are really quite important," says David Wright of the Union of Concerned Scientists. Those include such programs as the U.S.-Russian joint effort to control the supply of refined nuclear materials, which rulers like Saddam Hussein are trying to get to build their own bombs.

"National missile defenses provide no protection against the most likely future attacks on U.S. territory by weap-

ons of mass destruction, which would not be delivered by missile," said a letter to senators signed by six prominent scientists.

"The methods of delivery have already been demonstrated by the bombings of the World Trade Center in New York and the federal building in Oklahoma City, and the gas attack on the Tokyo subway," they said.

They also argue that, despite \$30 billion spent in more than a decade of work, major technological problems remain — in particular an inability to deal with simple countermeasures like decoys built into enemy missiles.

Under threat of a Democratic filibuster, the Senate will vote next week on a compromise that softens provisions in the bill, which potentially would have contradicted the treaty.

While construction of the defense system implies it would be widely deployed, Sen. Sam Nunn, D-Ga., said it was preferable to seek amendments to the treaty rather than give Russia "a

gratuitous poke in the eye" at a time when it is complying with treaty obligations to destroy its atomic arsenal.

"Don't do anything to the ABM treaty to jeopardize that," said Sen. Jeff Bingaman, D-N.M., whose home state hosts much SDI research and development.

"Contrary to the concerns of some, the Armed Services Committee never advocated abrogation of the treaty," said Sen. William Cohen, R-Maine, who helped craft the compromise that allayed Democratic concerns.

GOP lawmakers, who promised missile defense in the Contract with America, say Russia should not feel threatened by purely defensive U.S. moves.

And the GOP intends to move the missile defense closer to reality, especially given Clinton's refusal to test U.S. nuclear weapons.

"You cannot have it both ways," says Sen. Jon Kyl, R-Ariz. "If you're not going to test" the offensive weapons, "then you should be supporting missile defense."